MINNESOTA

The North Star State



The lakes of northern Minnesota were already ancient when the Ojibwe people named them. Stretching across a glacially carved landscape of pine, birch, and cold clear water, this region—known today as the Boundary Waters country—was home to one of the most significant food sources the continent had ever produced. The Ojibwe called it manoomin, meaning "the good berry," and they had harvested it from the shallow, slow-moving lakes and rivers of the region for centuries. What the rest of the world would come to know as wild rice was, to the Ojibwe, nothing short of sacred—a gift from the Creator, central to their ceremonies, their trade, and their survival through the long northern winters.

Harvesting manoomin was a communal act, done each September when the grain hung heavy over the water. Families paddled canoes through the rice beds, bending the stalks and knocking the grain loose with cedar knocker sticks, filling the hull until the boat rode low. The rice was then dried, roasted over fire to loosen the hulls, and stored for the months ahead. Eaten simply with venison broth or berries, it sustained entire communities through winters that could drive temperatures well below zero and bury the landscape under several feet of snow.

When French fur traders and voyageurs pushed into the Great Lakes region in the 17th century, they encountered manoomin along the waterways they paddled and immediately recognized its value. They carried it in their packs, traded for it at Ojibwe encampments, and kept it as a reliable staple on long wilderness journeys. The wild rice moved with the trade routes, and its reputation spread eastward. Later, as Scandinavian and German immigrants flooded into Minnesota in the mid-1800s, settling the farmlands of the south and the timber towns of the north, they encountered a grain unlike anything grown in the old country. Practical and resourceful by nature, they embraced it—pulling it into their own cooking traditions, combining it with the cream, butter, and root vegetables they knew from home.

It was in the farm kitchens and hunting-camp cookstoves of northern Minnesota that wild rice soup truly took shape. A cold autumn afternoon, a pot set over steady heat, the nutty fragrance of the rice opening up in warm broth—it became the kind of dish that called people in from the cold and kept them at the table. Thick with vegetables, enriched with cream, and grounded by that distinctive chewy grain with its deep, earthy flavor, the soup was both humble and deeply satisfying.

Today, wild rice remains one of Minnesota's most iconic ingredients, still harvested by Ojibwe families on the same lakes their ancestors paddled, and celebrated across the state as something genuinely irreplaceable. When you make this soup, you are stirring together centuries of history—Indigenous wisdom, wilderness survival, immigrant ingenuity, and the cold, clean spirit of the Northwoods. The rich, creamy bowl waiting at the end of it is more than worth the effort, and once you've made it, you'll understand why Minnesota has never let it go.



WILD RICE SOUP

One spoonful of wild rice soup—earthy, creamy, and warm—is all it takes to remember that the simplest bowls hold the deepest comfort.

Yield: 6–8 servings

INGREDIENTS

- 6 cups chicken broth (or vegetable broth for vegetarian)
- 1 cup uncooked wild rice, rinsed
- 4 Tbsp unsalted butter
- 1 medium onion, chopped
- 1 cup carrots, diced
- 1 cup celery, diced
- 1 cup mushrooms, sliced (optional but traditional in some Minnesota versions)
- 2 cloves garlic, minced
- 1 tsp dried thyme
- 1 bay leaf
- 1 tsp salt, plus more to taste
- ½ tsp black pepper
- 4 Tbsp all-purpose flour
- 2 cups whole milk (or half-and-half for creamier texture)
- 1 cup heavy cream
- 1 lb. boneless, skinless chicken breast or thighs, cooked and shredded (optional)
- 2 Tbsp fresh parsley, chopped

INSTRUCTIONS

1. *Cook the wild rice*: In a large pot, bring 4 cups of broth to a boil. Add wild rice, reduce to a simmer, cover, and cook for 45–50 minutes, until grains are tender and some have split open. Save any leftover cooking liquid and add it to the soup in step 3 in place of some broth.
2. *Make the base*: In a Dutch oven or large soup pot, melt butter over medium heat. Add onion, carrots, celery, and mushrooms (if using). Cook 6–8 minutes until softened. Stir in garlic, thyme, bay leaf, salt, and pepper.
3. *Thicken the soup*: Sprinkle flour over the vegetables. Stir constantly for 1–2 minutes to create a roux. Slowly whisk in remaining 2 cups broth, then add milk and cream. Bring to a gentle simmer, stirring until slightly thickened.
4. *Combine*: Add cooked wild rice and shredded chicken (if using) to the soup. Stir well. Simmer uncovered on low for 10–15 minutes to meld flavors.
5. *Finish and serve*: Remove bay leaf. Taste and adjust seasoning. Garnish with parsley before serving.